

REAL ROOMS · REAL RECEIPTS

The Room Planner

Room-by-room renovation checklists with budget columns that add up --
the same sheets I use on my own house.



BEFORE ANY ROOM

The order of operations

Every room in this planner follows the same spine. Do the steps in this order and you never undo finished work -- most budget blowouts are really sequence mistakes wearing a disguise.

1 Empty and decide.

Clear the room fully. Sort into keep / donate / trash before buying anything new -- the room you already own is the cheapest supplier.

2 Repair the bones.

Walls, outlets, squeaks, leaks, patches. Boring, cheap, and impossible to do neatly after the pretty things arrive.

3 Paint while it is empty.

Ceiling first, then walls, then trim. An empty room paints in half the time with none of the drop-cloth gymnastics.

4 Floors and rugs.

Whatever happens underfoot happens before furniture. Even just a rug: place it before the bed goes in, not after.

5 Big furniture, placed once.

Tape the layout on the floor first. Moving a wardrobe twice costs a Saturday; tape costs three dollars.

6 Lighting.

One overhead is a hallway; a room needs three sources. Lamps count. Warm bulbs (2700K) unless you are running a laboratory.

7 Textiles.

Curtains, bedding, cushions -- the softness budget. This is where a cheap room starts reading expensive.

8 Decor last, and less of it.

Art, plants, the shelf things. Stop one item earlier than you want to. You can always add; subtracting feels like failure.

ROOM SHEET

Guest bedroom

budget room

- ☐ Empty the room; sort keep / donate / trash
- ☐ Patch and repair walls, test every outlet and switch
- ☐ Paint: ceiling, walls, trim -- pick the color in the room's own light, not the store's
- ☐ Floor or rug down before any furniture
- ☐ Bed placed for walking space on both sides if it fits
- ☐ Bedside surface + lamp for each sleeper
- ☐ Blackout layer on the window -- guests sleep late, that is the point of guests
- ☐ Fresh bedding set reserved for guests only
- ☐ One luggage spot: bench, rack, or cleared closet shelf
- ☐ The guest test: sleep one night in it yourself

Item	Planned \$	Actual \$	Verdict
Paint + supplies			
Rug / flooring			
Bedding			
Lighting			
Window treatment			
Room total			

Verdict, written after living with it a month: **worth it** / **fine** / **skip next time**. The verdicts are the planner's whole secret.

ROOM SHEET

Mother-in-law suite

the big one

- ☐ Walk the plan with the person moving in -- their routines beat your Pinterest board
- ☐ Empty, repair, paint, floor -- the full spine, no shortcuts on this one
- ☐ Divider or layout that gives a sitting spot separate from the bed
- ☐ Closet or wardrobe they can reach every shelf of
- ☐ Lighting reachable from the bed -- no crossing a dark room
- ☐ Night path: bed to bathroom lit by one switch or motion light
- ☐ Grab points and no loose rugs on the walking lines
- ☐ A private touch that is theirs alone: their chair, their photos, their clock
- ☐ Sound check: can they hear the household? Can the household hear them?
- ☐ One week in: sit down and ask what is wrong with it, then fix that list

Item	Planned \$	Actual \$	Verdict
Paint + repair			
Wardrobe / closet build			
Divider			
Lighting			
Furniture			
Room total			

ROOM SHEET

Hallway

weekend project

- ☐ Clear everything, including the stuff that "lives there" -- it does not
- ☐ Patch the scuffs and door dings; hallways take the most hits in the house
- ☐ Paint -- lighter than you think; hallways get no windows of their own
- ☐ Runner sized so it leads somewhere, not floats in the middle
- ☐ Lighting every 8 feet or so; a dark hallway shrinks the whole house
- ☐ Wall plan taped up before any nails: frames, mirror, hooks
- ☐ The end of the hallway gets ONE thing: lamp table, art, or plant
- ☐ Nothing on the floor when you are done. Hallways hold light, not storage

Item	Planned \$	Actual \$	Verdict
Paint + supplies			
Runner			
Lighting			
Wall decor / frames			
Room total			

ROOM SHEET

Home office works for a living

- ☐ Empty, repair, paint, floor -- the spine, even for "just an office"
- ☐ Desk faces the light source, screen perpendicular to the window
- ☐ Chair before decor: hours in it beat glances at it
- ☐ Power routed BEFORE the desk is loaded -- tape the cable path
- ☐ Task lamp + one warm room light; overhead alone is interrogation lighting
- ☐ One closed-storage piece so the room can shut up at 5pm
- ☐ Video-call wall: what the camera sees, kept deliberately simple
- ☐ If it doubles as a guest room: daybed over sofa bed, and test the change-over

Item	Planned \$	Actual \$	Verdict
Paint + supplies			
Desk			
Chair			
Lighting			
Storage			
Room total			

THE WHOLE HOUSE

Project rollup

One line per room. "Planned" is written before the first receipt; the gap column is where the honesty lives -- track it while it is small.

Room	Planned \$	Actual \$	Gap	One-line verdict
Guest bedroom				
In-law suite				
Hallway				
Home office				
House total				

I post every one of my own sheets -- prices, mistakes, and the verdicts a month later -- at thesunnyroom.co and on the Pinterest boards. Come compare receipts.